vided a monthly allowance of Rs 1,500.

The party's poll manifesto, titled 'Didir 10 Protigya', is an extension of an already tested welfare model rather than a fresh set of promises. At its core is Duare Chikitsa, a proposal to deliver healthcare to people's doorsteps through annual camps across the state, based on the Duare Sarkar model. The manifesto also promises an expanded welfare net, including a promise to continue Lakshmir Bhandar as long as there is a TMC government, a Rs 30,000 crore agriculture push, universal housing and piped drinking water, besides expansion of pensions and education infrastructure. Alongside this, it outlines an economic vision to double Bengal's current economy of Rs 20 lakh crore by linking welfare delivery with growth, and to make the state a trade gateway for eastern India. "Mamata's schemes and her network of beneficiaries are very strong in rural Bengal, which is where her votes come from. Anti-incumbency against her is sharper in urban areas," says political analyst Biswajit Bhattacharya.

Apart from branding the TMC govt as 'anti-Hindu', the BJP's chargesheet lists its alleged 'failures' across 14 sectors, including corruption, lawlessness and lack of security, casting the election as a choice between "fear and trust"

Twin Offensive

The BJP pins its campaign on two broad allegations: that the TMC government is steeped in corruption and that it is 'anti-Hindu'. On March 28, Union home minister Amit Shah released a chargesheet in Kolkata listing the Mamata government's alleged 'failures' across 14 sectors, including corruption, lawlessness and security lapses, casting the upcoming election as a choice between "fear and trust". The chargesheet also flagged concerns over women's safety, healthcare, education and administrative efficiency. The BJP has even fielded Ratna Debnath, mother of the R.G. Kar Medical College and Hospital doctor whose rape and murder in August 2024 had sparked wide outrage. State BJP president Samik Bhattacharya believes this time his party will finally fulfil its long dream of capturing Bengal, saying, "The people have made up their minds. Trinamool will go, Trinamool is going. Trinamool is already gone. No force on earth can keep them in power."

Even without a formal manifesto, the BJP has promised an Annapurna Bhandar—its counter to Mamata's Lakshmir Bhandar—with higher cash transfers, along with a commitment to implement the 7th Pay Commission and release the long-pending dues to state employees within 45 days of coming to power. It has also pledged to allocate land for border fencing within the same time-frame, directly feeding into its anti-illegal immigration plank, while repeatedly invoking the idea of an 'appeasement-free' and 'corruption-free' government to contrast with the ruling regime. On employment, the BJP is promising a five-year age relaxation for government job aspirants affected by recruitment scams, along with filling all vacant posts through transparent processes.

The BJP's vote share has grown phenomenally in the past two assembly elections, with the Congress and the Left Front experiencing a total collapse. It rose from 10 per cent in 2016 to 37.9 per cent in 2021, though still about 10 percentage points short of the TMC's 48 per cent. While party sources believe that their prospects of coming to power have risen significantly, it has much catching-up to do.

Suvendu Adhikari, the leader of the Opposition and a former TMC leader who defected to the BJP in 2021, remains key to the saffron party's poll strategy. In 2021, he defeated Mamata in Nandigram by 1,956 votes, forcing her to seek election in Bhabanipur. This time, he is chasing Mamata down on her home turf of Bhabanipur to make a point, while also defending Nandigram against his former aide Pabitra Kar, now with the TMC. While Suvendu functions as the Hindutva poster boy, Samik, lauded for his oratory skills, has been positioned to woo the bhadralok—the educated class of Bengalis.

The Congress and the Left add another layer of uncertainty to an already fragmented electoral landscape. This time, the two are contesting separately, breaking from past tactical alliances and effectively turning the contest into a multi-cornered fight. In districts such as Murshidabad, Malda and Uttar Dinajpur, where the Congress retains a residual organisational base, even a modest vote runoff can prove decisive. The 2021 results showed how a split in minority votes between the TMC and Congress allowed the BJP to win two seats despite being less endowed in terms of a base. But this time, the BJP may have to bear the fallout of the alleged persecution of Bengali speakers—especially Muslims—across the country in the name of evicting illegal Bangladeshis, an issue the TMC has weaponised. With the voter pool itself now under stress, the presence of Congress and Left candidates could once again fragment votes just enough to alter outcomes in closely-fought seats.

More than anything else, the 2026 election in West Bengal won't be a contest about anti-incumbency and welfare alone, it will hinge as much on who gets to vote. If the SIR reshapes the electorate, it could alter outcomes beyond the reach of campaigns. ■